

spirituals (although Hiawatha is about American Indians).

Regrettably, he needed approval for his libretto from a committee at the Conservatory, and the submitted texts failed to please them, for reasons known best to themselves. Dvořák eventually siphoned material for the opera into a different project instead: his Symphony No. 9, “From the New World.” Upon its 1893 premiere, an interview with Dvořák in The New York Herald quoted the composer: “The second movement ... is in reality a study or sketch for a longer work, either a cantata or an opera which I propose writing, and which will be based upon Longfellow’s Hiawatha ... The scherzo of the symphony was suggested by the scene at the feast in Hiawatha where the Indians dance.”

Eventually, the homesick Dvořák returned to Prague in 1895, becoming director of the city’s Conservatory. During his last years he focused on composing operas and symphonic poems, among them The Golden Spinning-Wheel and The Noonday Witch. In 1897, his daughter Otilie, herself a fine musician, married his favorite pupil, the composer Josef Suk; the family remained close until Dvořák’s death in 1904, at age 62.

Tragically, Otilie died the following year, at only 27. Suk’s “Asrael” Symphony paid tribute to both his wife and her father.

But Dvořák’s legacy is still strong. His Czech musical heirs were Suk and Leoš Janáček. He might also have been proud to see US composers Copland, Barber, Ives, and Bernstein bring a truly national style blazing to fruition in the 20th century.